

gaming in the comforts of a home. In addition, the popularity of its franchises, such as Sonic the Hedgehog, Disney's Aladdin, Joe Montana Football and other sports games. A move that set them apart from their competition at that point was their hosting of more mature content, such as the uncensored version of Mortal Kombat. Initially, the Genesis faced numerous problems due to Nintendo's strict and borderline monopolising practices. Companies like Capcom chose not to port popular titles like Street Fighter II, though they jumped onto the Sega ship later. Notably, many third-party developers supported the Genesis early on, one of the big names being Electronic Arts.

On seeing Sega's rise to the top of the market, Nintendo began to scramble and tried to keep up by releasing its Super Nintendo Entertainment System in 1991 in the North American market. It was released as the Super Famicom in Japan in 1990. The console competed with Sega's Genesis by improving graphics and increasing the color palette of the system to 32,768 colors.

A particularly new and novel feature was the introduction of regional lockout, which prevented releases in a certain region from being compatible with releases in another region. From a gaming point of view, SNES recaptured its supremacy in the gaming consoles market by developing a variety of enhancement chips built into game cartridges.

The release of these two consoles locked down the market in a console war, with each company trying to one-up the other. Sega gained a strong foothold with the Genesis, and the release of Sonic the Hedgehog, which directly competed with Nintendo's Mario series. The consoles hit a minor speedbump when media started focusing on the over-the-top violence depicted in many video games.

The first game to receive a bad rap was Midway's Mortal Kombat, which was accused of portraying excess violence that could influence children. While Nintendo made the choice to censor the game and pare down the blood with sweat and the dismembering finishing move with less violent ones. However, Sega took a chance and established the first American Videogame Rating Council, that gave Sega's version of the game a rating of MA-13.

The fourth generation of video game consoles saw the reintroduction of handheld consoles in a big way. As the release of the Game & Watch series had received positive reviews, Nintendo went ahead and released its Nintendo Game Boy in 1989. An 8-bit handheld video game device with interchangeable cartridges, the first version of the Game Boy came bundled with Tetris as the in-pack game, thus attracting non-gamers to the device